

PSCI 2223 Introduction to International Relations / Fall 2025

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Canvas course page: <https://canvas.colorado.edu/courses/124722>

Meeting time: MW 10:10-11 am

Lecture location: Math 100

Office hours: see Canvas

Note: In addition to the MW 10:10 am lectures, you will be attending weekly recitation sessions with your Teaching Assistant. See your TA's syllabus for their contact info, office hours, section-specific assignments and due dates, etc.

COURSE DESCRIPTION

This course explores the fundamental concepts, theories, practices, and problems of international politics, such as anarchy, power, security, the nature of international economics, and origins and roles of international organization and law. Upon completing this course, students will be familiar with the major theories of international politics and be able to understand fundamentals of key international issues relating to international security, economic relations, and organizations.

THE PHILOSOPHY OF MULTIPLE VIEWPOINTS

All students taking this course are to be treated with respect and are encouraged to bring up viewpoints related to the class topics informed by their backgrounds and worldviews. On an international level, the class tackles issues such as inequalities in political and military power, in economic resources, as well as discrimination, by addressing how these issues are connected with warfare, economic welfare, and institutional integration related to both more and less developed parts of the world. The students are strongly encouraged to further think about these themes from multiple points of view in the context of the assigned readings and research report assignments.

COURSE REQUIREMENTS

Reading Materials

1. Older and newer editions of this textbook are acceptable: Mingst, Karen A. and Heather McKibben. 2021. *Essentials of International Relations*. 9th ed. Norton.
2. Supplementary materials, available through Canvas

Student Initiative

In addition to **reading assigned materials thoughtfully and thoroughly** and **participating in classes regularly**, students should be alerted to the obvious fact that it will not be easy to summarize the complexity of our topics in terms of a few concepts and theories. Students should acquire the habit of regularly reading world news stories to learn about and keep up with international developments.

Examinations

There will be two exams based on lectures, recitation sections, assigned readings, and class discussions. A description of the exam format will be given prior to the exam dates.

Research Reports

Guidelines, assignments, deadlines, and criteria of evaluation are outlined toward the end of the syllabus.

Participation

Participation in the recitation sessions is expected. The students are expected to offer their own insights based on class materials. To encourage participation, the instructor and TA may use random questioning or unannounced quizzes.

Attendance

Regular attendance in both lectures and recitations is expected. Please note that excessive excused or unexcused absences will also hurt your participation grade, because one cannot participate in class discussions if one is not present in class.

COURSE RULES

Grading Policy

Midterm Exam	25%	Research Reports	30%
Final Exam	25%	Recitation	20%

Class Policies

1. All class work must be the student's own work. This means that the use of Artificial Intelligence (AI) to write assignments, take exams or quizzes, or perform other class-related tasks is expressly prohibited. All class work is eminently doable with a normal level of effort devoted to a typical class, so AI assistance is not needed to do well in the class. Please take the opportunity to learn and develop yourself intellectually rather than look for shortcuts that will shortchange you in the long run. AI infractions will be treated as plagiarism violations, and sanctified as described immediately below.
2. All academic work must meet the University's standards for academic honesty. Each student is responsible to inform themselves of these standards before conducting any academic work. My academic dishonesty policy is very simple: you will receive a failing grade for the class if you are found cheating on examinations, plagiarizing the work of others, attempting to turn in assignments used in previous classes, or sign the attendance sheet for another student, along with all other possible infractions noted in the University's policy on academic dishonesty. Moreover, disciplinary proceedings to dismiss you from the University may be initiated. I **will not** tolerate academic dishonesty and you **will** face the harshest punishment possible if you attempt it.
3. Assignments are to be turned in by the stated deadline. Failure to meet an assignment deadline does not entitle the students to make up the work at a later time.
4. Exceptions to the class requirements and rules are granted at the instructor's discretion, only under circumstances of extreme personal emergency or serious illness. In all instances, appropriate evidentiary documentation will be requested and must be turned in within 3 days of the original absence.
5. Students may request their TA to re-read exam answers or papers that they feel have been unfairly evaluated. Requests for re-evaluation must be submitted within a week after it has been returned to the class or the final grade posted, whichever is earlier. The written re-evaluation request statement must explain specifically why the student thinks that the grade should be reconsidered and what grade the assignment deserves. Re-evaluation will be conducted *de novo*, which may result in a lower, higher, or the same grade.
6. Accommodations based on disability and/or religious beliefs will be made whenever possible. But, it is the student's responsibility to let their TA know about **needing such accommodations within the first two weeks of class**. Accommodation requests after this time period may not be granted.

7. The syllabus is a general plan for the course; deviations may be necessary and will be announced. 8. Additional short readings (e.g. articles, news stories) may be assigned as the semester progresses.

8. All the lecture materials are considered to be the intellectual property of the instructor and are only to be used by the students enrolled in the class for their own education. Any distribution of the said materials and/or use for commercial purposes **is expressly prohibited**.

9. See the course Canvas page for additional university-mandated statements on topics such as discrimination, harassment, COVID, etc.

10. All students are expected to complete assigned readings before they are discussed in class and they are expected to discuss and respond to random questioning.

COURSE OUTLINE: TOPICS AND READINGS

I. Introduction

- Mingst: Chapters 1, 2, 4, and 5
- Canvas: Ra'anana "The Nation-State Fallacy"
- Canvas: Barber "Jihad vs. McWorld"

II. Key Theories of IR

A. (Neo)Realism

- Mingst: Chapter 3: Realism section
- Canvas: Hobbes "The State of Nature ..."
- Canvas: Thucydides "The Melian Dialogue"
- Canvas: Waltz "The Origins of War in Neorealist Theory"

B. (Neo)Liberalism

- Mingst: Chapter 3: Liberalism section
- Canvas: Pease "Philosophical Roots of Liberalism"
- Canvas: Moravcsik "Taking Preferences Seriously"

C. Marxism

- Mingst: Chapter 3: The Radical Perspective section
- Canvas: Pease "Marxism"

III. Key Topics in the Study of International Politics

A. Security

- Mingst: Chapter 6
- Canvas: Morgan "Deterrence: A Conceptual Analysis"
- Canvas: Ziegler "Disarmament"
- Canvas: Ziegler "Collective Security"
- Canvas: Russett "The Fact of the Democratic Peace"

B. International Economic Relations

- Mingst: Chapter 8
- Canvas: Frieden and Lake "International Political Economy"
- Canvas: Coughlin et al. "Protectionist Trade Policies ..."
- Canvas: Lenin "Imperialism: The Highest Stage of Capitalism"
- Canvas: Cohn "Dependency Theory"
- Canvas: Russett & Oneal "Triangulating Peace" esp. pp. 127-133, 154-155

C. International Institutions and Law

- Mingst: Chapters 9 and 7 (in that order)
- Canvas: Pease “Liberalism and the Nature of International Organizations”
- Canvas: Akenhurst “Is International Law Really Law?”
- Canvas: Russett, Oneal & Davis “The Third Leg of the Kantian Tripod” esp. pp. 441-449, 462

Midterm Exam: Monday, October 13, 10:10 am

Final Exam: Friday, Dec. 12, 10:30 am

RESEARCH REPORTS

This assignment asks you to summarize and evaluate **TWO** articles from the below top peer-reviewed scholarly journals on the topic of international relations, that is politics between (NOT within) countries.

RESEARCH REPORT ARTICLE APPROVAL

Due by 5 pm **September 12 for Article #1** and **October 31 for Article #2**, 2.5% of the course grade each.

To assure that your chosen article meets the below criteria, submit the pdf of the article via Canvas. **All the below requirements MUST be met** (i.e. not meeting any one of these will result in a grade of **zero** on the entire Research Report assignment).

1. The article must be from one of these top peer-reviewed political science journals: *International Studies Quarterly*, *International Organization*, *Journal of Conflict Resolution*, *Journal of Peace Research*, *Review of International Organizations*, or *Conflict Management and Peace Science*. Journals such as the *British Journal of Political Science*, *Journal of Politics*, *American Journal of Political Science*, *Political Behavior*, *Political Research Quarterly*, and *American Political Science Review* also qualify, though these journals tend to have fewer international relations articles. Access the journal articles via the CU library <https://libraries.colorado.edu> while on campus or use the VPN connection <https://oit.colorado.edu/services/network-internet-services/vpn> if not on campus.
2. The article’s topic must be international relations (i.e. politics between or among countries and NOT domestic politics that simply takes place in one or more foreign countries). Examples of topics include international (not civil) war, economic sanctions, international organizations, international trade, alliances, international environmental cooperation or conflict, etc.
3. Only actual full-length articles will count; research notes, data features, book reviews, etc. or articles focusing on non-international relations topics or that are from non-approved journals do not count.

RESEARCH REPORT ASSIGNMENT

Due by 5 pm **October 17 for Article #1** and **December 3 for Article #2**, 12.5% of the course grade each.

Note: the assignment will receive **the grade of zero** if the article has not been previously approved.

Assignment format and content: the report is to be 1,500-1,800 words in length, broken down into the below-identified sections. Use headings and sub-headings but **avoid direct quotes**. Suggested format: single-spaced, 11 pt. Times New Roman font, 1” margins. Turn in via Canvas.

1. Citation: provide the full citation for your approved article in MLA or similar format.
2. Research question: in **your own words**, explain what the authors are investigating (e.g. why do some countries come to their allies’ aid while others do not). 1-2 paragraphs

3. Theory: **in your own words**, explain what the authors' argument is (e.g. democracies are more likely to be reliable alliance partners than autocracies). 2 paragraphs minimum
4. Evidence: **in your own words**, explain what kind of evidence the authors use to evaluate their argument (e.g. statistical analysis of all the world's countries, 1816-2020). 2 paragraphs minimum
5. Evaluation: in **your own words**, explain whether there some parts of the argument that are not supported by the evidence? What are some of the other strengths and weaknesses? What do the authors do well and what can be improved? What other critiques can you offer? 2-3 paragraphs min

Failure to meet the above-specified deadlines will result in a **10% a day penalty**. Please note that the due dates are known well in advance, so you need to plan accordingly.

Grading criteria for the assignments:

- | | |
|------------------------|---------------------------|
| 1. objectivity | 4. organization |
| 2. quality of research | 5. writing style, clarity |
| 3. quality of analysis | 6. mechanics and grammar |

Students who have difficulty with rhetoric are encouraged to use the University's resources to help them write better and purchase a writer's manual such as Strunk and White's *Elements of Style*.